The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran's foreign minister said his country was exchanging messages with **America** through third countries, but that it had "no intention of negotiating" on Donald Trump's 15-point ceasefire proposal "for now". Mr Trump said Iran's leaders are "afraid" to admit to talks. Earlier an Iranian official called the proposal "excessive" and set out Iran's own conditions for ending the war, which include sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz.

In a landmark decision, a jury in California found that **Google** and **Meta** intentionally built their social-media platforms to be addictive, and that this lured in children and was harmful to their mental health. The firms, owners of Youtube and Instagram respectively, were ordered to pay $3m to a 20-year-old plaintiff. Thousands of similar lawsuits against social-media firms are pending. Both companies will appeal.

Mr Trump said his summit in Beijing with **Xi Jinping**, China's president, had been rescheduled to May. Their original meeting, due later this month, was postponed because of the Iran war. The conflict brings a new test for the leaders, who also disagree over Taiwan and trade, among many other things. In addition, Mr Trump said he would host Mr Xi in Washington later this year.

Belarus's autocratic president, Alexander Lukashenko, flew to Pyongyang to meet Kim Jong Un, **North Korea's** dictator. The two countries are important allies of Russia and support its war against Ukraine. Mr Kim has supplied Vladimir Putin, Russia's leader, with troops for his invasion. Mr Lukashenko laid a wreath on Mr Putin's behalf at Kumsusan mausoleum, where North Korea's former leaders lie.

Consumer confidence in **Britain** fell to its lowest level in more than two years, according to a survey by the British Retail Consortium, a trade association. Households' view of the state of the economy in the coming three months plunged from minus 30 in February to minus 53 in March. Britons fear inflation will surge because of the war in Iran.

Matt Brittin, a former Google executive, will be the **BBC's** next boss. The previous director-general resigned over a programme that falsely made it appear as though Mr Trump had called for rioters to attack the Capitol in Washington, DC on January 6th 2021. The president is suing the broadcaster. Mr Brittin must also deal with tough competition from streaming services and declining trust in traditional news sources.

Workers found a skeleton beneath a church in Maastricht that may belong to **D'Artagnan**, the French soldier who inspired the hero in Alexandre Dumas's novel, "The Three Musketeers". The swashbuckler was killed during a siege of the Dutch city in 1673. A French coin from 1660 and a musket ball buried nearby point to a possible match. Archaeologists will compare DNA from the remains with D'Artagnan's descendants.

Figure of the day: $2.3bn, the value of De Beers, a diamond company, down from $12.75bn in 2011. Read about why Botswana's effort to buy a bigger chunk of De Beers could backfire.

Photograph: AP

The known unknown for America and Iran

Donald Trump's claim that Iran is negotiating with America to end the war and that it has given America a "very big present" relating to oil and gas should be treated with a large dose of scepticism. It is neither clear who his Iranian interlocutors are—nor whether, if they do exist, they have any influence.

The negotiations are reportedly based on a 15-point plan drawn up last year, when the two countries sought to reach an agreement on Iran's nuclear programme, among other things. Iran's state media has mocked the president's claim. On Wednesday a military spokesperson said that Mr Trump was "negotiating with himself". Meanwhile thousands more US Marines as well as troops from the 82nd Airborne Division are on their way to the region. It is uncertain whether Mr Trump wants to de-escalate or simply calm jittery markets before beginning a new stage of the war. His inconsistency suggests he may not know himself.

Illustration: David Simonds

Northern Europe strengthens its defences

On Thursday leaders of countries in the Joint Expeditionary Force, a northern European military alliance, gather in Helsinki. They will discuss their support for Ukraine and the overall state of European security. The British-led club has stepped up efforts to deter Russian aggression in the Baltic Sea, the North Atlantic and the Arctic. In September it will hold joint naval, air and land exercises, called Lion Protector, across Norway, Iceland and the Danish straits. It hopes to improve collaboration to protect infrastructure and to align command-and-control capabilities.

The Trump administration has been calling on Europe to do more to protect the High North. The JEF gives Britain a way to show leadership of Europe's response. The country is set to assume command of NATO's Atlantic and Arctic headquarters from America, and has committed more troops to defending the Nordic region. That may not placate Donald Trump, who has been berating Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, for failing to back America's war on Iran.

Joint Expeditionary Force members
Iceland
Finland
Russia
Norway
Estonia
Sweden
Latvia
Denmark
Lithuania
Ireland
Netherlands
Belarus
Britain
Poland
Germany
Ukraine
Bel.
Czech Rep.
Lux.
Slovakia
Aust.
Hung.
France
Romania

Photograph: Alamy

Novo weighs its future

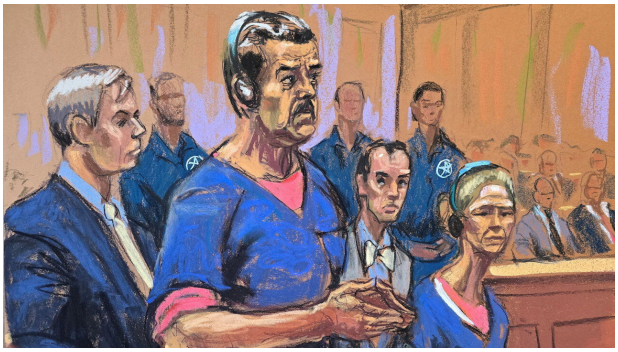
Novo Nordisk holds its annual general meeting on Thursday at a difficult moment. The Danish drugmaker pioneered a new class of weight-loss medicines with the launch of Wegovy in 2021. Yet it has lost ground to Eli Lilly, an American rival. Lilly's weight-loss drug, Zepbound, now outsells Wegovy by more than two to one in America. Meanwhile, cheap copycats are conquering markets such as India and China, where patent protection for semaglutide, Wegovy's active ingredient, has expired. Novo's share price has fallen by more than three-quarters from its peak in June 2024.

The firm is fighting back. An oral version of Wegovy, launched in America in January, has been popular, though Lilly is expected to introduce its own pill soon. Novo has also struck a deal with Hims, a telehealth firm, which will now sell Wegovy instead of copycat versions of the slimming jab. Investors in Novo will hope to hear that the worst is over.

Shedding the pounds

Novo Nordisk, share price, $

Source: LSEG Workspace



Photograph: Reuters

Nicolás Maduro back in the dock

On Thursday Nicolás Maduro, Venezuela's former president, and his wife, Cilia Flores, are expected to appear before a judge in New York for the second time. The Trump administration, which seized the couple in Caracas on January 3rd, accuses Mr Maduro of four crimes, including conspiracy to commit "narco-terrorism" and to smuggle cocaine into America. Ms Flores is accused of similar crimes. Both deny the accusations.

At this hearing the defence will urge the judge to dismiss the case. They argue that the Trump administration has interfered by blocking the couple's access to Venezuelan government funds to pay their legal fees. The judge is highly unlikely to throw out the case. But this is only an early skirmish in a long and complex legal war. Vast reams of evidence must be gathered and shared, and then a trial date set. America's capture of Mr Maduro and Ms Flores was sudden and swift. Their trial will probably be anything but.

Photograph: Anna Maria Maiolino/Regina Vater

A lively show about ageing

Want to live longer? You're in luck: the effort to slow human ageing, long associated with quackery, is now all the rage. Serious-minded scientists and self-interested billionaires alike are looking to develop cutting-edge treatments to prolong lifespans.

A show opening on Thursday at the Wellcome Collection in London is one of the first museum exhibitions to explore the theme of ageing in science and culture. "The Coming of Age" displays objects such as a silver sake cup—the sort that Japan awarded to centenarians for decades, until they grew too numerous for the government to sustain the expense—and a walking stick carved from whalebone that was once owned by Charles Darwin. Artworks and vintage advertising show how contemporary beliefs about ageing have been shaped. A clip of "Don't Die", a documentary about Bryan Johnson, a venture capitalist who wants to live forever, plays on loop. The whimsical show fittingly bursts with life.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: In poker, what is the term for a hand that contains three of a kind and a pair?

Wednesday: What is the term for the annual celebration that occurs in many countries when the crops have been gathered?

Competitions are for horses, not artists.

Bela Bartok